

TRACES VINGETTES



TANYA – FOSTER PARENT

Tanya has been fostering Malik (11) and Ava (7) for eight months, long enough for everyone in the agency to see her as the “stable home” they can lean on. From the outside, her life looks ideal—steady middle-school teaching job, supportive partner, spare bedrooms, and years of foster-care training under her belt. Inside the house, though, things are unraveling faster than she can patch them. Malik has begun punching walls hard enough to leave dents, and Ava hoards food under her bed. Each crisis chips at Tanya’s confidence; she feels like she should know what to do, but nothing in the trainings prepared her for the emotional landmines embedded in these kids’ daily routines.

The caseworkers keep asking her to “hang on a little longer,” promising services that never quite materialize. The only therapist available is a once-a-month telehealth clinician who changes every two or three sessions. Her partner has grown resentful of the constant chaos and nightly arguments erupt over safety, schedules, and whether they can keep doing this. Tanya finds herself turning down extra hours at school, avoiding friends, and dreading the sound of her phone because it’s usually a teacher, caseworker, or crisis call. Everyone keeps telling her how lucky the kids are to have her. No one asks what it’s costing her to be the stable adult holding the whole structure upright.

Devon – Kinship Placement

Devon has been caring for his nephew Carter (9) for nearly a year since his sister entered rehab for the third time. The agency calls it “kinship care,” which sounds warmer than “emergency placement,” but the reality is the same tangle of paperwork, court dates, and promised services that never quite arrive. Devon works overnight shifts at a distribution center because the pay differential helps cover Carter’s needs, then tries to stay awake during the day to manage school pickup, homework battles, and the meltdowns that erupt without warning. Carter’s teacher emails weekly about missing assignments and “concerning behavior”—stealing pencils, tearing up his work, telling elaborate lies. The school counselor suggested an IEP evaluation four months ago. Devon has called twice to follow up; no one calls back.

His caseworker rotates every six weeks, so he’s constantly re-explaining Carter’s history to someone new who promises to “look into” therapy options. Meanwhile, Carter refuses to sleep in his own bed, wakes up screaming most nights, and has started asking when his mom is coming to get him—questions Devon can’t answer honestly without breaking the kid’s heart. Devon’s girlfriend moved out last month, saying she “couldn’t do this anymore.” His friends stopped inviting him places after he canceled too many times. His manager has warned him about falling asleep during breaks. The only people who call are asking him for something: the school wanting another meeting, the caseworker needing more documentation, his sister wanting unsupervised visits.